ConsignO Desktop

The software is used by over 57,000 engineers and architects, across Canada, to securely sign more 18 million critical documents. Being professions that handle documents with sensitive information, it enables users to validate documents and sign them with secure, legally compliant digital signatures.

A digital signature is an electronic signature backed by a digital certificate that provides proof of identity. The certificate cryptographically binds the signature and PDF, securing it with a tamper-proof seal.

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Our Team



MAG
Senior Product Manager



DF
Product Owner



Marisa
Senior UX Designer



CI
Senior UX Researcher



XL
Senior Software Developer



TC
Full Stack Developer



CB
Backend Developer



JG
QA



MCL
QA

Why Version 4?

Version 3 relied on an outdated code, which made it difficult to find developers familiar with the language. Furthermore, it failed meet the performance that more current languages provide in digital products. Needing to start from scratch presented an ideal opportunity to redesign the UI and UX, addressing recurring user feedback highlighted in the annual marketing survey. Furthermore, the revamp will help better position the product to target the U.S. market.

Timeline + Stages

April - June ‘23

Understand + Explore

- Product Discovery
- Low Fidelity + High Fidelity Mockups
- Interviews + Tests
- Design System Base

Jan - Oct ‘24

Refine

- Iterating on Designs
- Managing Design System
- Usability Testing

Nov ‘24

Beta Launch

- Pre Testing to Launch
- Survey for initial feedback, 30 and 60 days
- User Interviews

Late Q1 2025

V1 Launch

- Iterating on released features
- Working on features excluded in beta
- New features
- Further testing

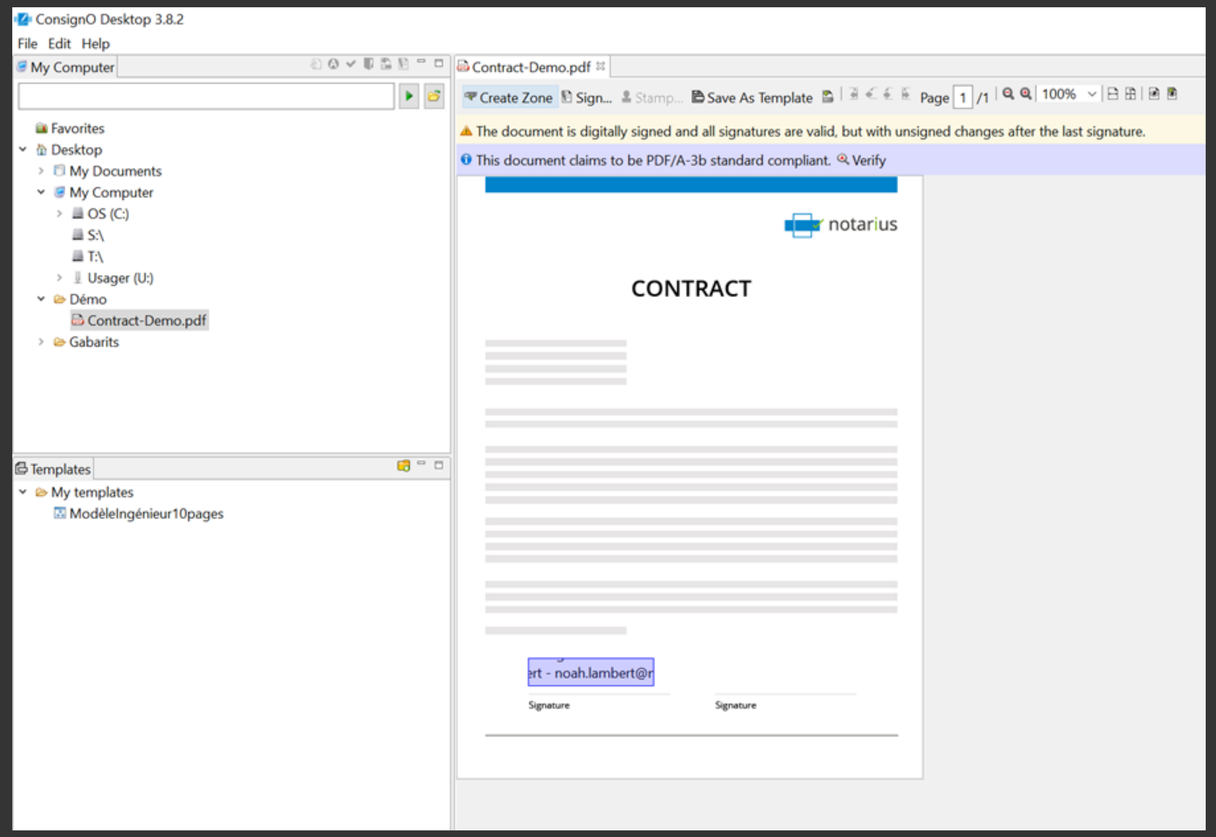
Survey Results

The annual marketing survey started in 2022 and was sent out at year end. It consisted of 30 questions. The following 2 were very helpful:

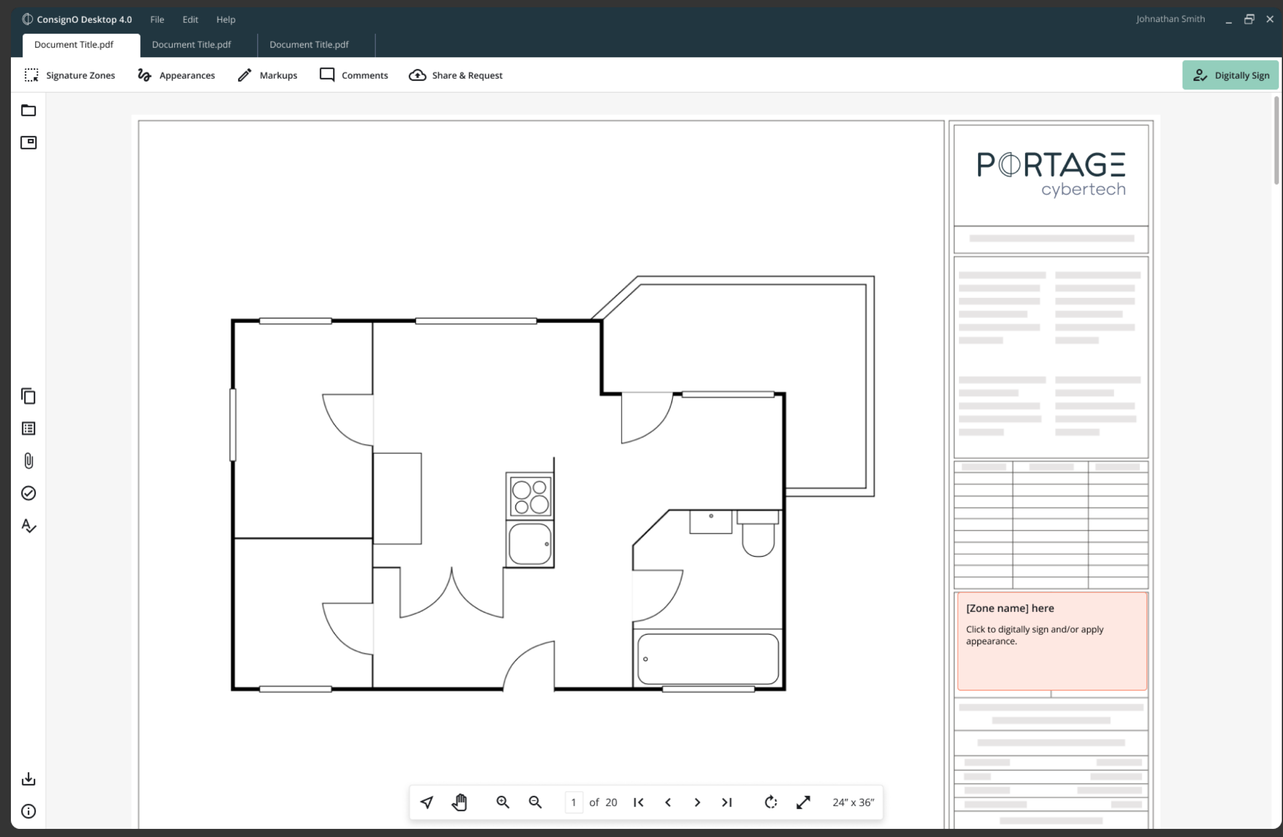
- Overall, what is your level of satisfaction with ConsignO Desktop?
- How could we improve our products and services?

- Very Satisfied: **27.5%**, Satisfied: **61.7%**
- Feedback for specific feature: **27.6%**
  General UX/UI: **19.6%**
  Speed/Reliability: **15.2%**
  Mouse Clicks: **4%**
- Different terms used for ‘sign’ and ‘stamp’

Design



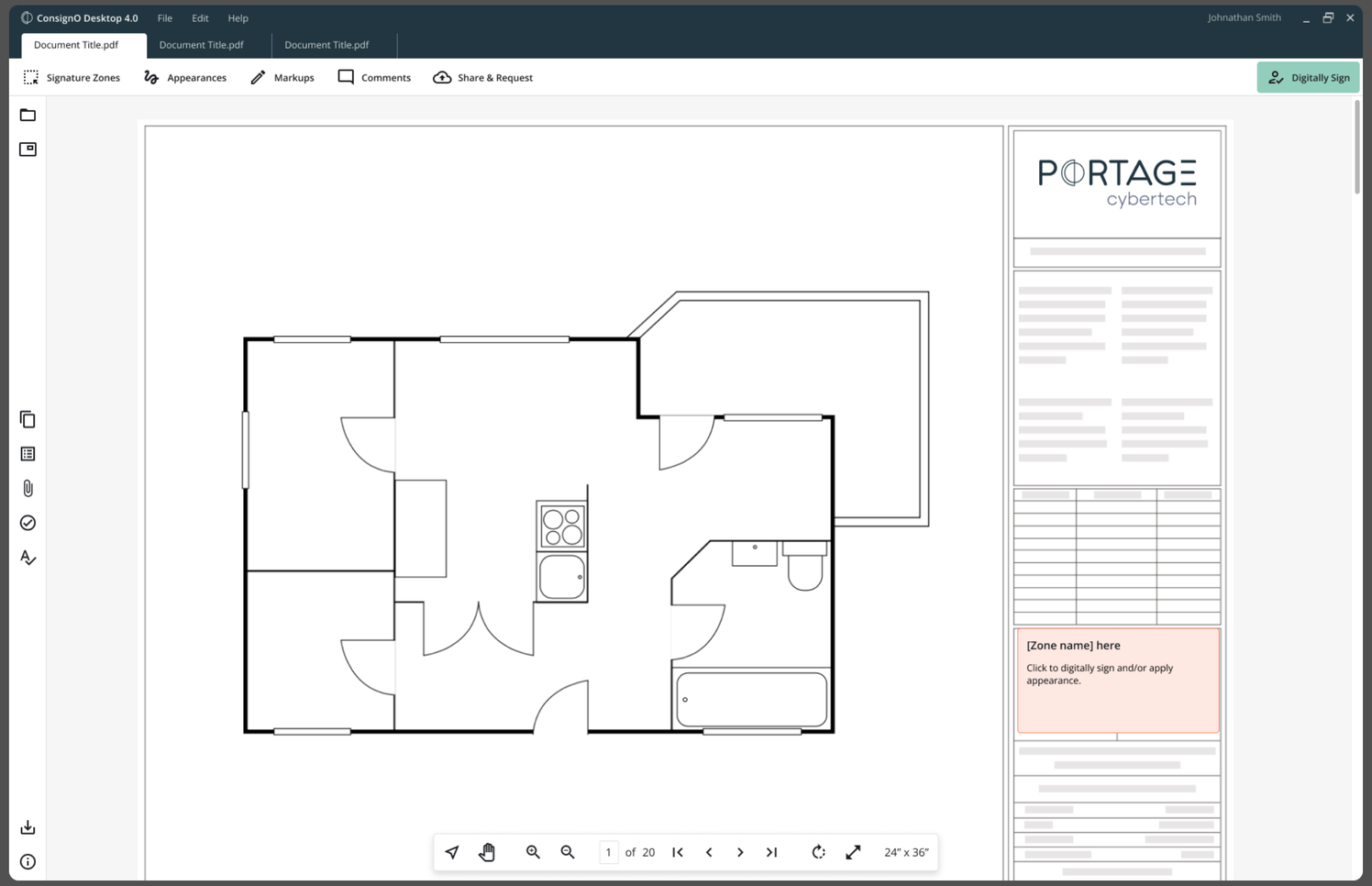
Version 3



Version 4

Problems & Opportunities

Requirements



Concerns

- Secondary top nav has inconsistent UX
- Colours were not accessible *
- Overall design used too many colours + type styles
- Improved button styling
- Use of complex icons for actions

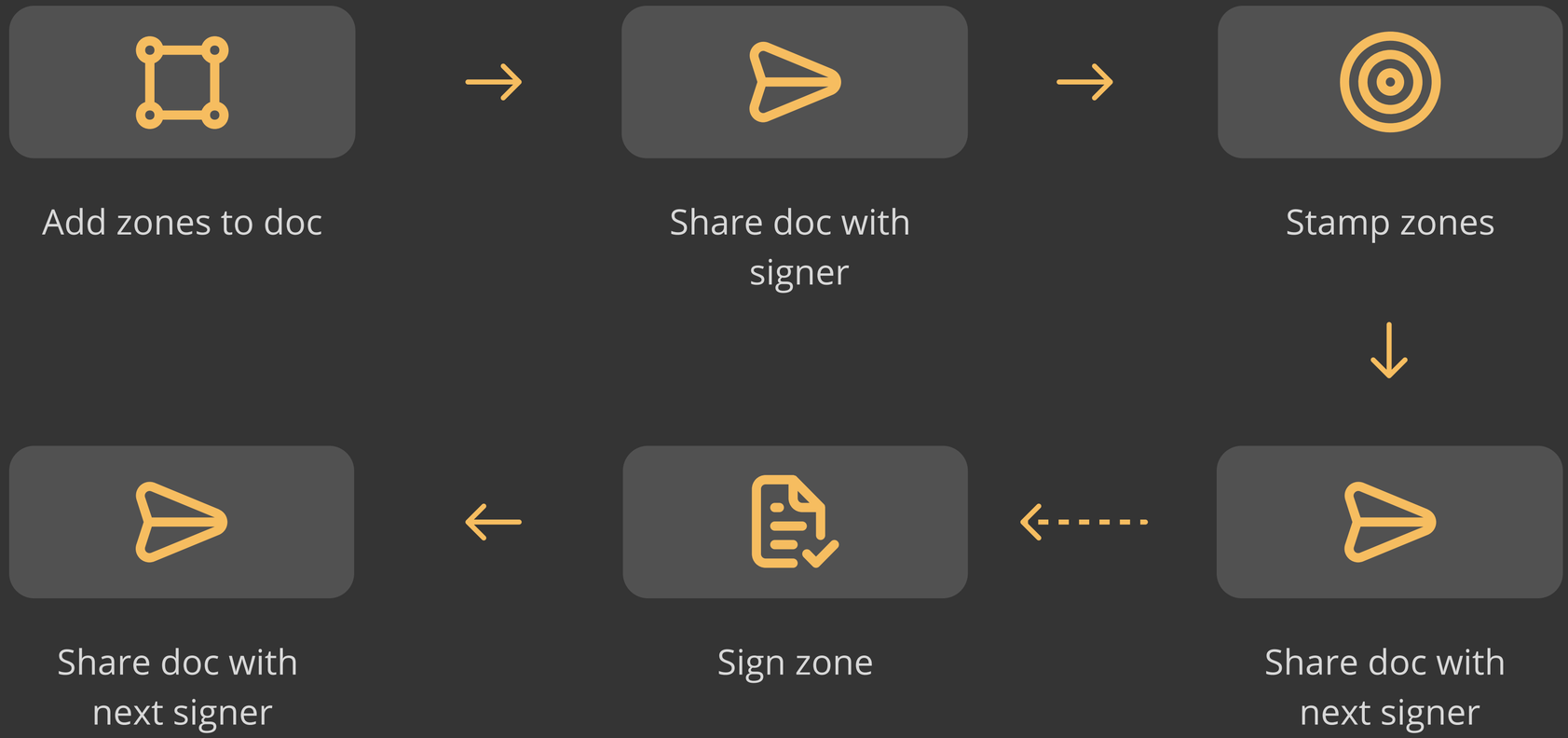
* At this time there is no comparable guideline for accessibility in desktop app like web has. I did make use of WCAG aspects that were compatible in desktop (eg colour, spacing and sizing for icons and fonts).

Key Priority

- Signing in a document is the most important thing to get right in the redesign.
- The current designs open as a modal which feels dates and limits the UX.
- In version 3, the signing action has to be done one selection at a time. Version allows for multiple selection.

Signing Flow

With a large number of zones

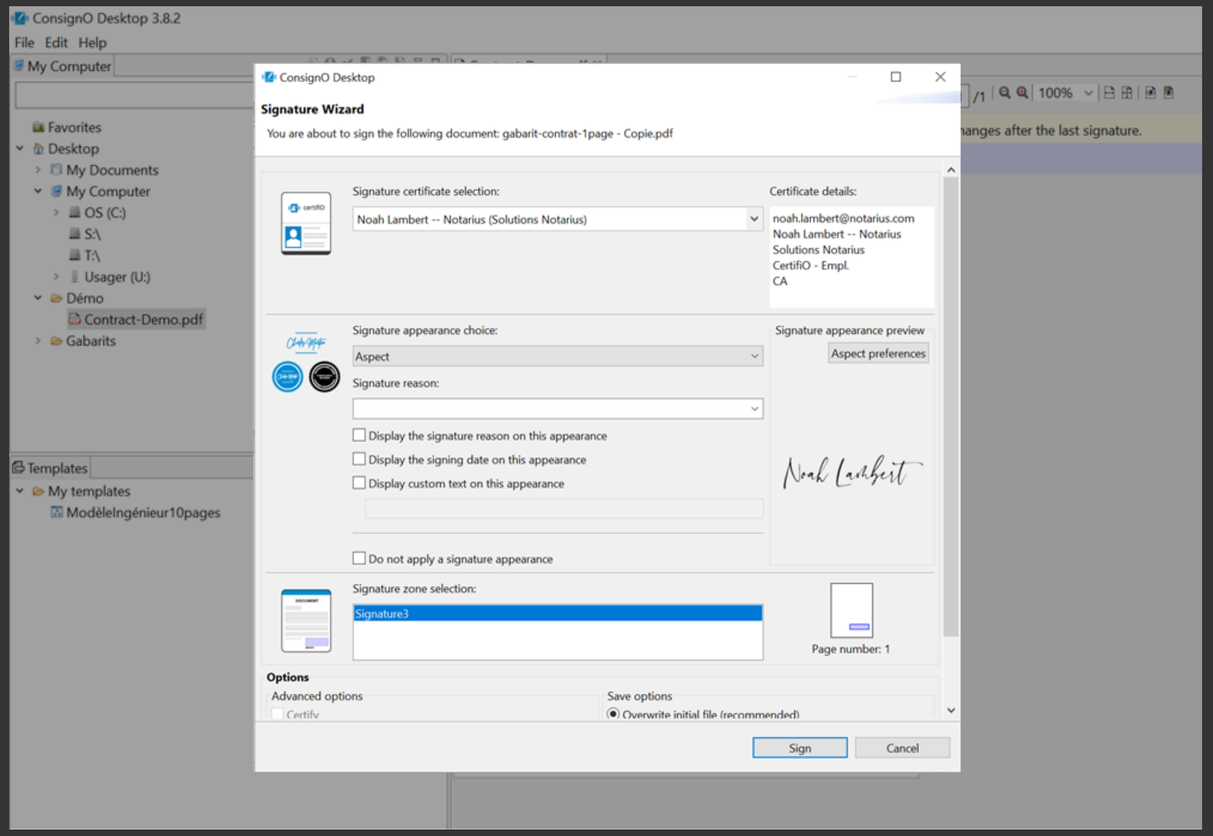


Signing Flow

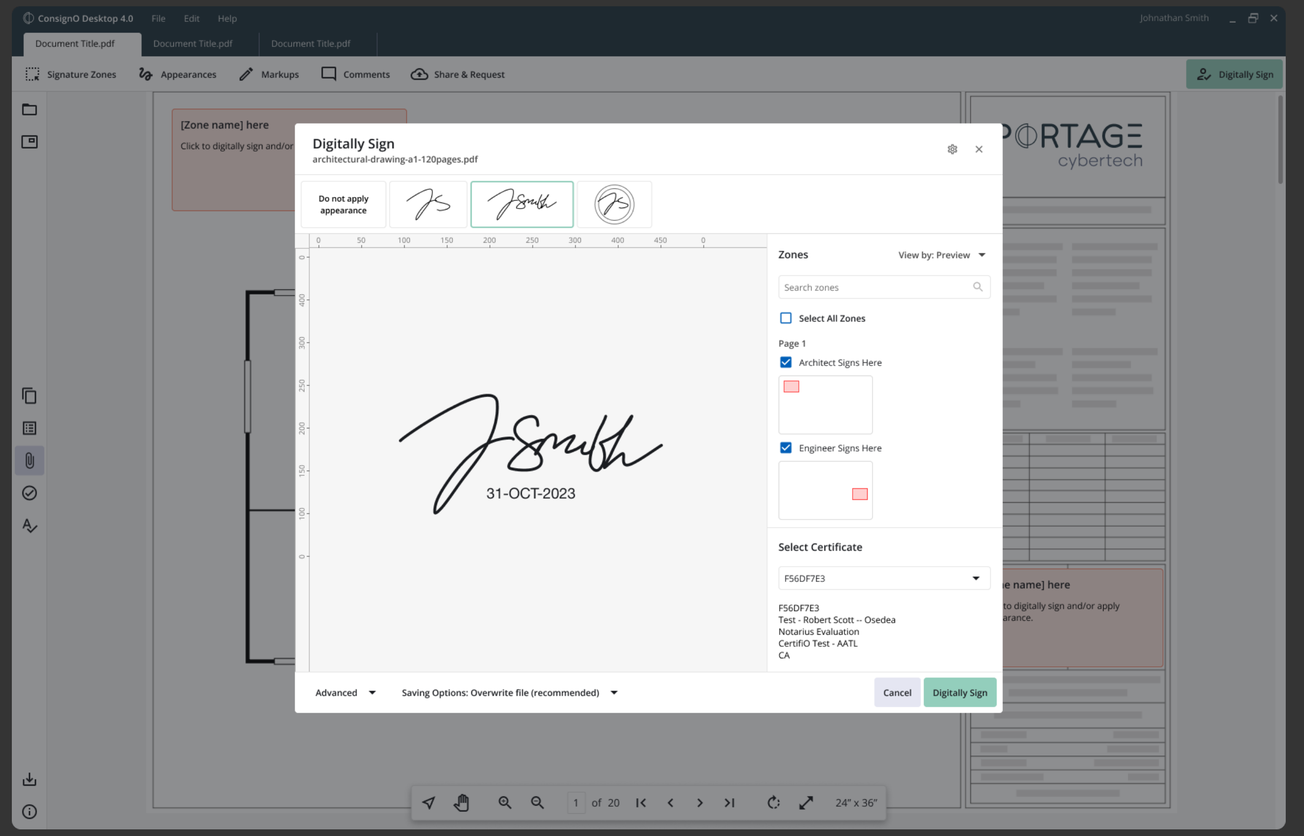
With a small number of zones



Signing UI



Version 3



Version 4

How might we...

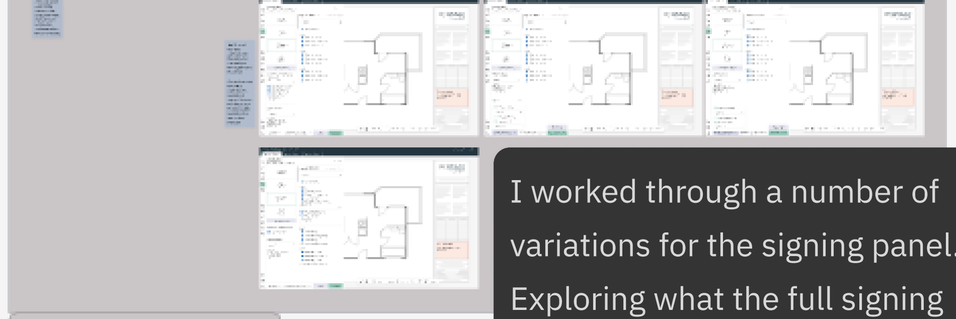
Make signing more efficient?

Make it easier to avoid errors when signing and stamping documents?

Handle large document formats in the product?

Preserve a sense of simplicity while adding more power and functionality to the product?

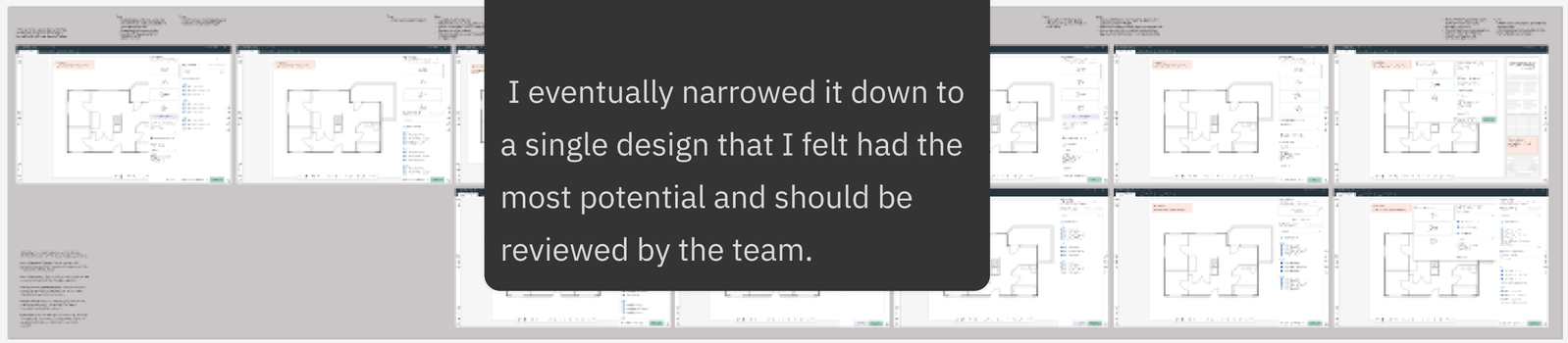
Product & Design Decisions



Second Draft → Marisa

I worked through a number of variations for the signing panel. Exploring what the full signing would be for each one.

I eventually narrowed it down to a single design that I felt had the most potential and should be reviewed by the team.



v1 Wide Panel → Marisa



★ V2 Multi-Step Panel → Marisa



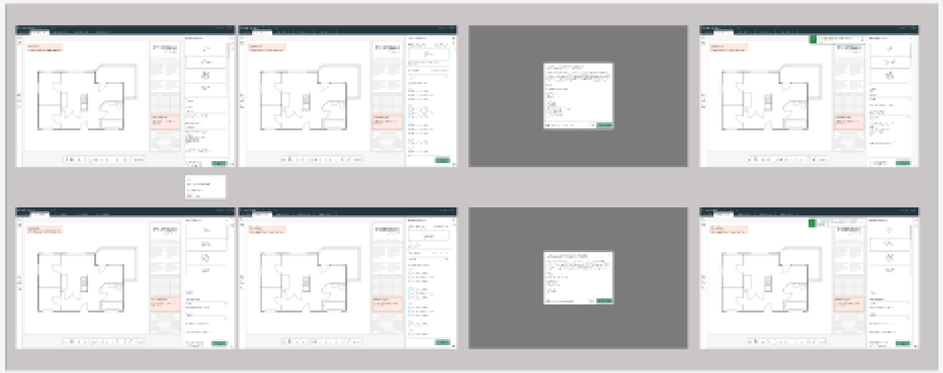
Panel w Top Tab → Marisa



Stamp + Sign Panel - Option 1

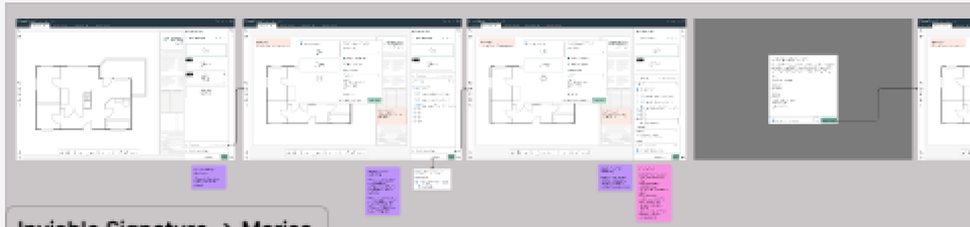


Stamp + Sign Panel - Option 2

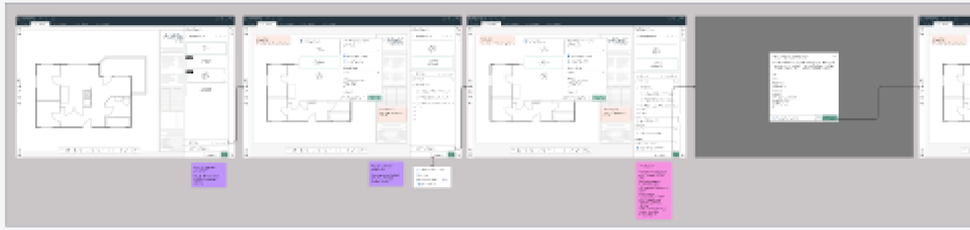


Visible Signature→ Marisa

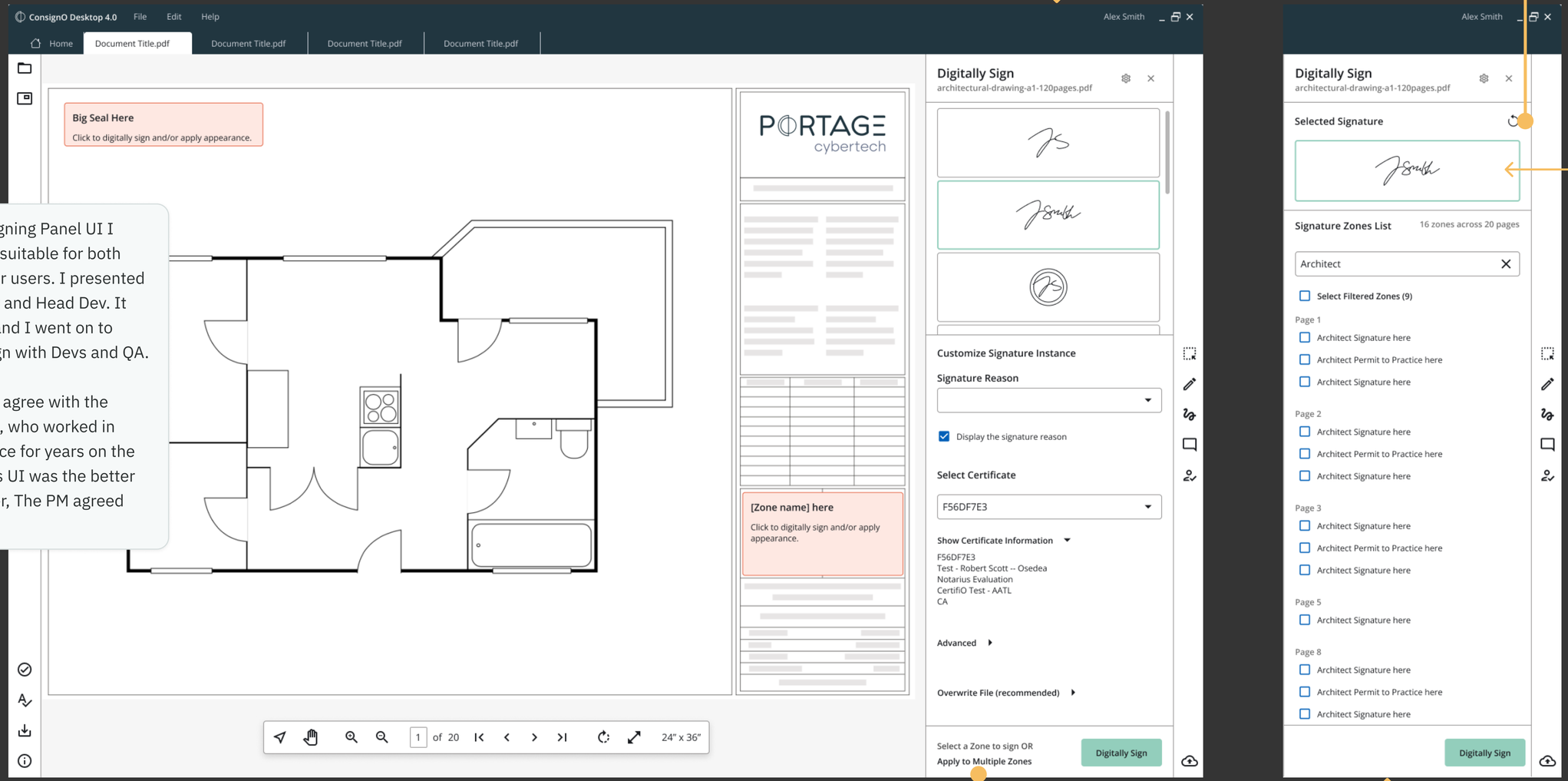




Invisble Signature → Marisa



Design



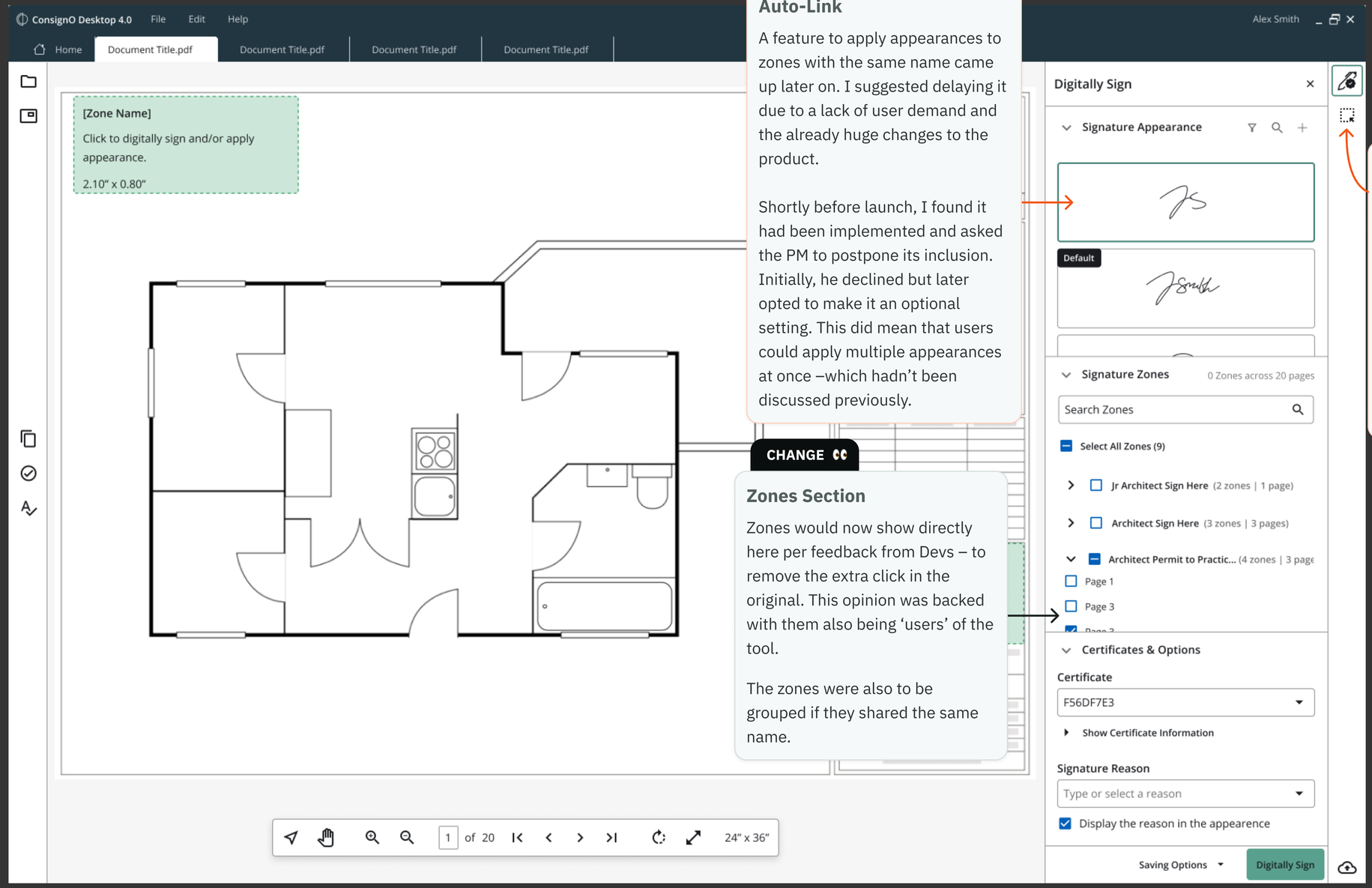
This was the Signing Panel UI I expected to be suitable for both entry and power users. I presented it to the PM, PO and Head Dev. It was approved and I went on to share this design with Devs and QA.

The devs didn't agree with the design. One QA, who worked in Customer Service for years on the product felt this UI was the better option. However, The PM agreed with the Devs.

Users are shown the selected appearance which will be applied.

If signing multiple zones in one go, a user can click here to change the UI.

Jan 12-31, 2024



QUESTION

Auto-Link

A feature to apply appearances to zones with the same name came up later on. I suggested delaying it due to a lack of user demand and the already huge changes to the product.

Shortly before launch, I found it had been implemented and asked the PM to postpone its inclusion. Initially, he declined but later opted to make it an optional setting. This did mean that users could apply multiple appearances at once –which hadn't been discussed previously.

CHANGE

Zones Section

Zones would now show directly here per feedback from Devs – to remove the extra click in the original. This opinion was backed with them also being 'users' of the tool.

The zones were also to be grouped if they shared the same name.

QUESTION

Button Order

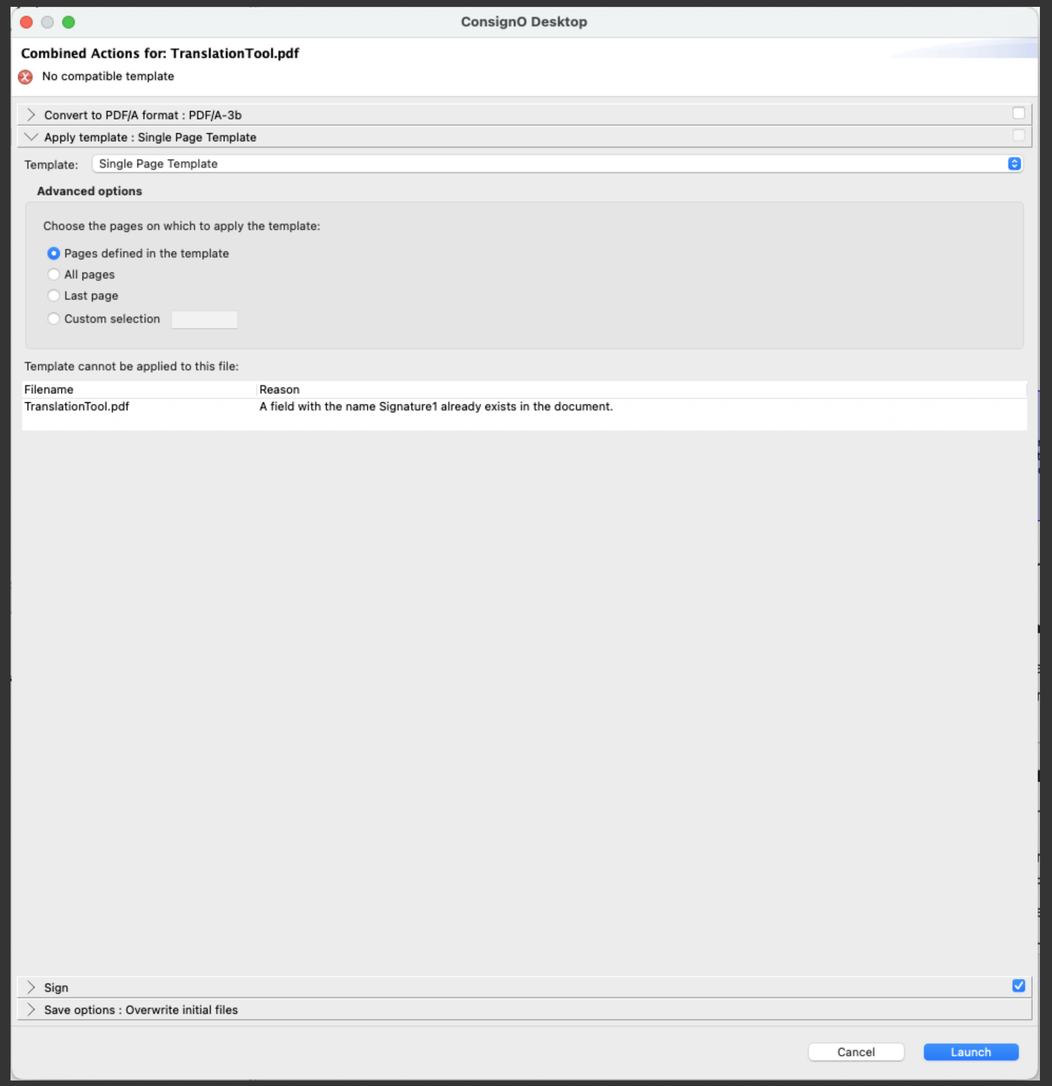
PM wanted Sign to be first followed by Stamp. I asked if the plan was to remove Stamp now that users could Sign multiple zones. Stamp would remain so I didn't think this order was good since Sign will disable Stamp and could increase user errors. PM acknowledged this but still felt it was best.

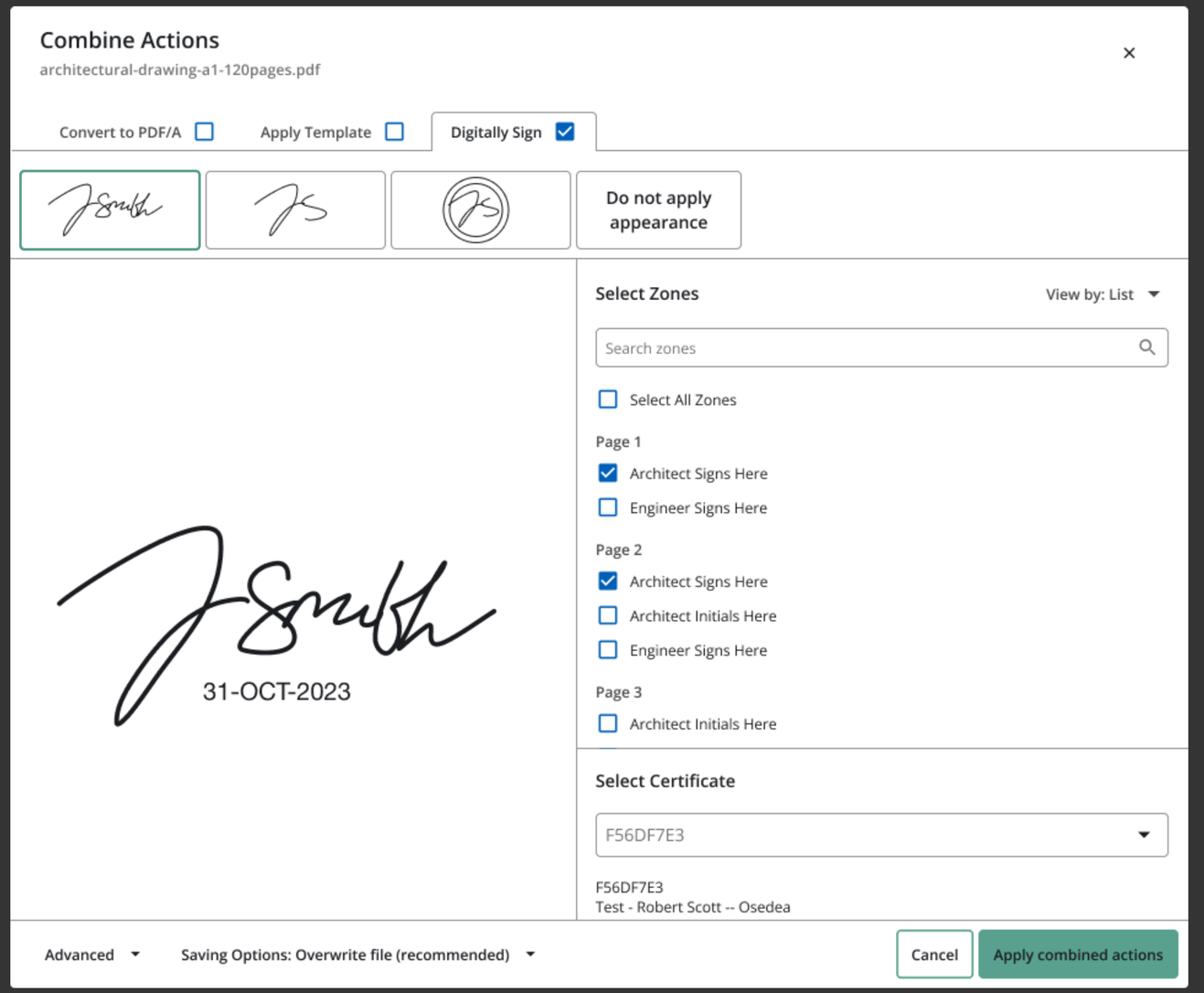
Feb 5, 2024

Combine Actions Overview

- This is a popular function in the platform but didn’t make the cut for the Beta.
- Combine Actions allow users to quickly execute ConsignO Desktop’s four most common steps on document from a single window.
- It is most commonly launched from the desktop (rather than in app).

Design


ConsignO Desktop
Combined Actions for: TranslationTool.pdf
No compatible template
Convert to PDF/A format : PDF/A-3b
Apply template : Single Page Template
Template: Single Page Template
Advanced options
Choose the pages on which to apply the template:
Pages defined in the template
All pages
Last page
Custom selection
Template cannot be applied to this file:
Filename
Reason
TranslationTool.pdf
A field with the name Signature1 already exists in the document.
Sign
Save options : Overwrite initial files
Cancel
Launch


Combine Actions
architectural-drawing-a1-120pages.pdf
Convert to PDF/A
Apply Template
Digitally Sign
Do not apply appearance
31-OCT-2023
Select Zones
View by: List
Search zones
Select All Zones
Page 1
Architect Signs Here
Engineer Signs Here
Page 2
Architect Signs Here
Architect Initials Here
Engineer Signs Here
Page 3
Architect Initials Here
Select Certificate
F56DF7E3
F56DF7E3
Test - Robert Scott -- Osedea
Advanced
Saving Options: Overwrite file (recommended)
Cancel
Apply combined actions

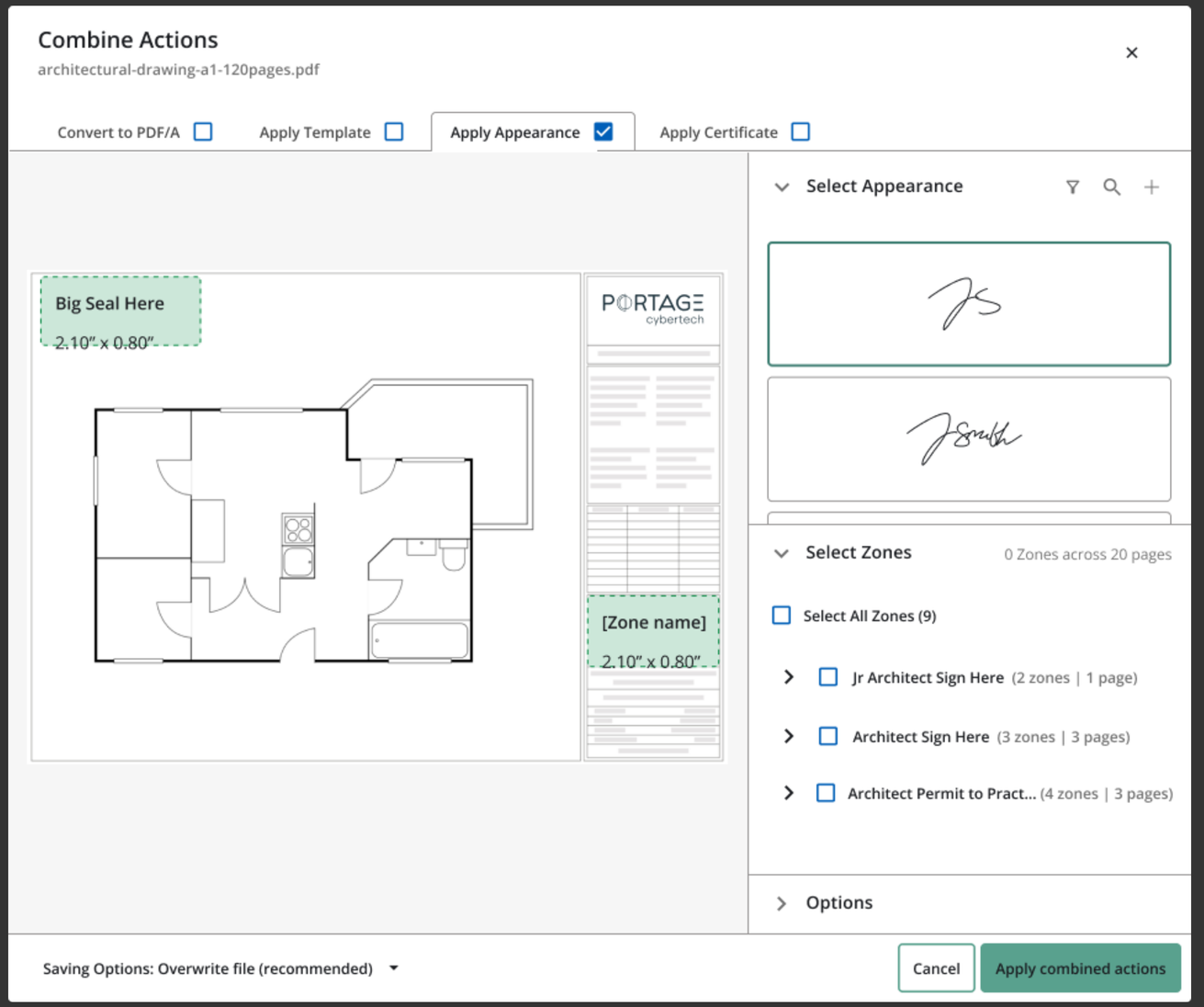
Design

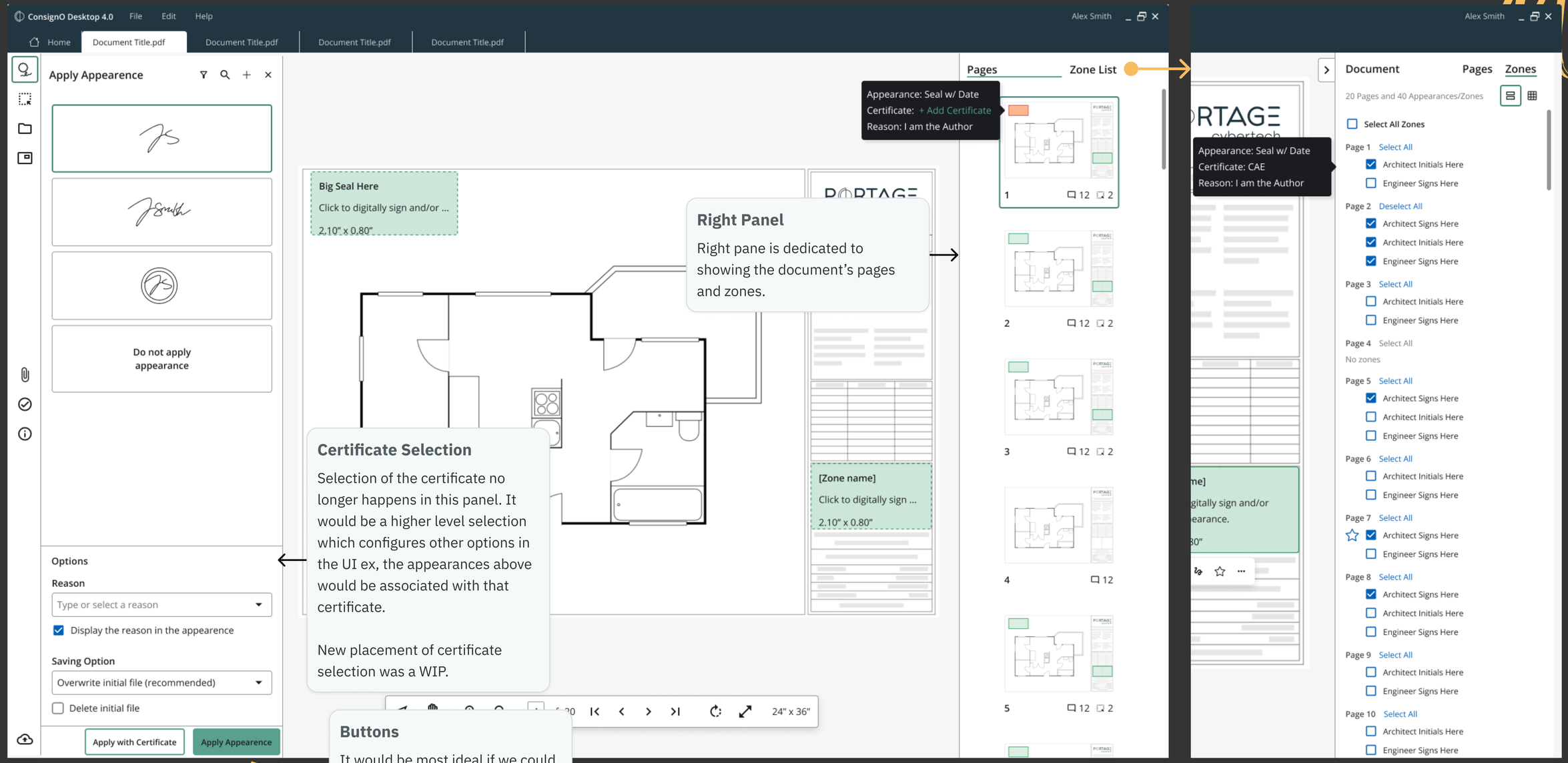
In my design attempt, I wanted to provide the user more context by giving a preview window of the document.

I quickly realized this was now a mini version of the full product and wondered what benefit served. Why in V3 are users signing documents sight unseen?

In later User Testing users talked about previewing the document with other tools since V3 is so slow. I asked the PM if this feature was made to avoid using the UI and it's slow PDF viewer. It was before his time but felt this was a good guess. This had me turn my focus back to the main UI and how I could make it the best experience that it made this redundant.

Revised design is near the end.




ConsignO Desktop 4.0
File
Edit
Help
Alex Smith
Home
Document Title.pdf
Document Title.pdf
Document Title.pdf
Document Title.pdf
Apply Appearance
Do not apply appearance
Options
Reason
Type or select a reason
Display the reason in the appearance
Saving Option
Overwrite initial file (recommended)
Delete initial file
Apply with Certificate
Apply Appearance
Big Seal Here
Click to digitally sign and/or ...
2.10" x 0.80"
[Zone name]
Click to digitally sign ...
2.10" x 0.80"
24" x 36"
Pages
Zone List
Appearance: Seal w/ Date
Certificate: + Add Certificate
Reason: I am the Author
Right Panel
Right pane is dedicated to showing the document's pages and zones.
Certificate Selection
Selection of the certificate no longer happens in this panel. It would be a higher level selection which configures other options in the UI ex, the appearances above would be associated with that certificate.
New placement of certificate selection was a WIP.
Buttons
It would be most ideal if we could work with a single button to further reduce complexities. Would need more info about the tech limits and whats feasible.
Alex Smith
Appearance: Seal w/ Date
Certificate: CAE
Reason: I am the Author
Document
Pages
Zones
20 Pages and 40 Appearances/Zones
Select All Zones
Page 1 Select All
Architect Initials Here
Engineer Signs Here
Page 2 Deselect All
Page 3 Select All
Page 4 Select All
No zones
Page 5 Select All
Page 6 Select All
Page 7 Select All
Page 8 Select All
Page 9 Select All
Page 10 Select All

Oct 28, 2024

Usability Testing

Session Overview

Round 1

Method: Moderated A/B Testing

Timeline: April - May 2024

Participants: 6

Experience: 3-16 yrs

Usage: Daily to every few months

Appearances: Several

Certificates: 1-6

Round 2

Method: Moderated A/B Testing

Timeline: July - Aug 2024

Participants: 6

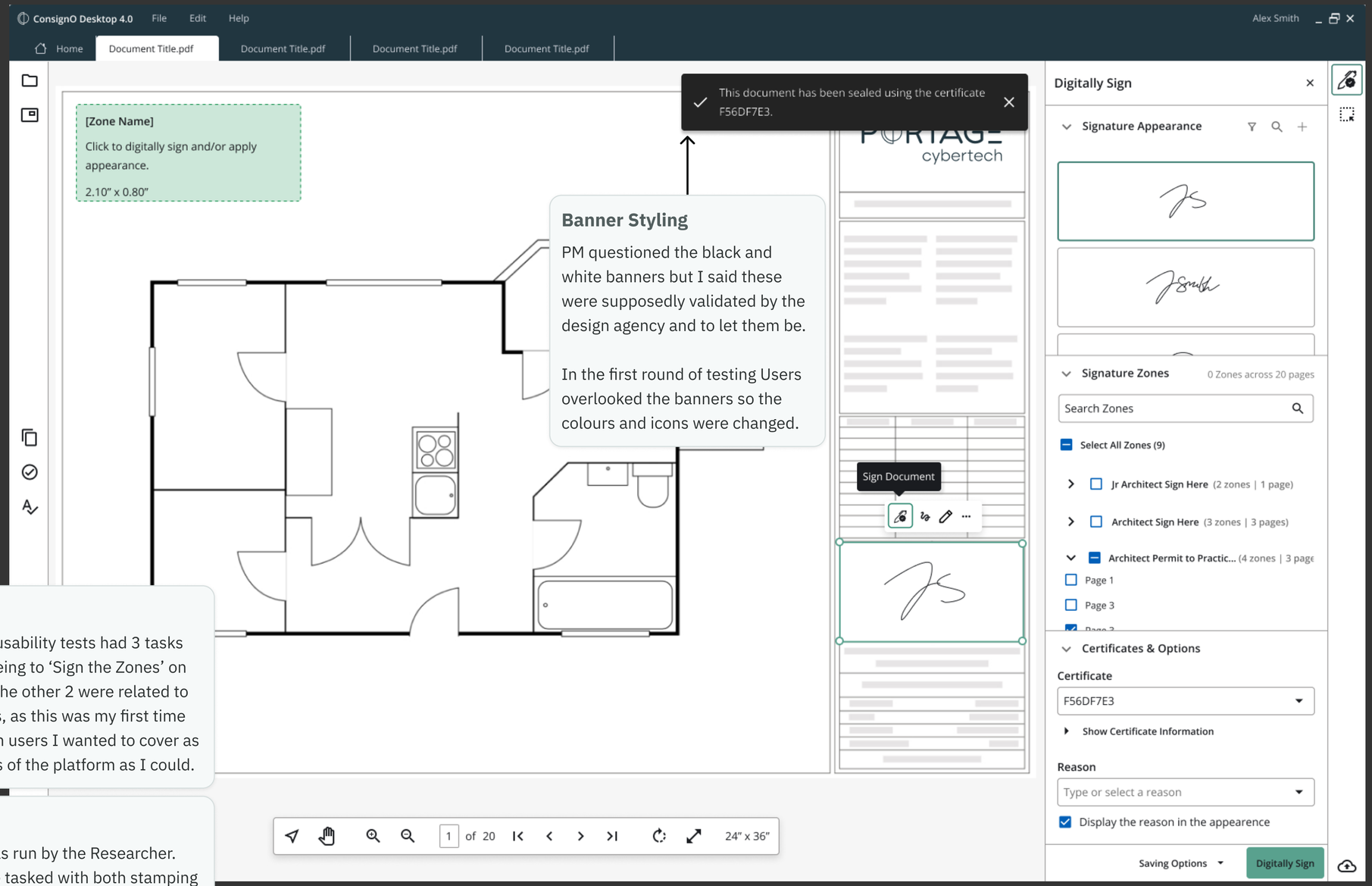
Experience: 2-23 yrs

Usage: Daily to every few months

Appearances: 1-9

Certificates: 1-3

Research



Round 1

The initial usability tests had 3 tasks with one being to 'Sign the Zones' on the page. The other 2 were related to other areas, as this was my first time testing with users I wanted to cover as many areas of the platform as I could.

Round 2

This set was run by the Researcher. Users were tasked with both stamping and signing zones in the document.

Research Insights

Starting Point to Sign

10/12 testers gravitated to the zones looking for actions to start the signing process. They also felt they should be able to finalize the signature from here – ignoring the button in the panel.

Terminology Confusion

R1 when asked to sign the 2 zones, users instead looked to start with stamping. Overall, users agreed the current terminology was confusing – especially when first encountering the tool.

IxD Between Zone + Side Panel

Users prefer that clicking the sign/stamp action on a zone opens the related panel **and** displays a preview of its appearance on the selected zone – rather than only one of these options

Zone Selection

Users seemed to ignore the zone names and randomly pick. Is this because they didn't add the zone's themselves, is the UI too busy or ambigious? Exact issue to target is unclear...

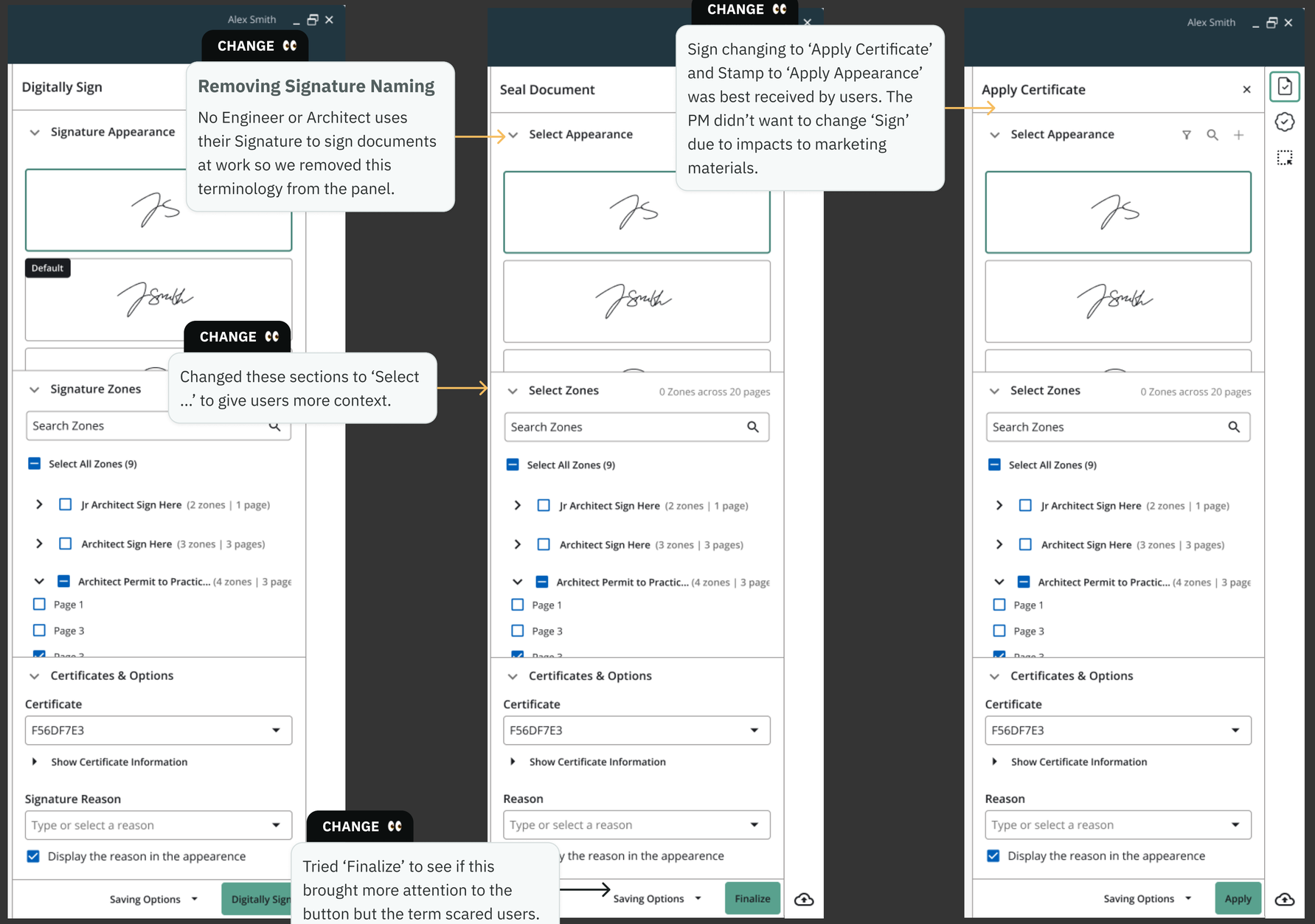
Signing Multiple Zones

The majority of users didn't find signing multiple zones to be as useful as the stamping function. R2 rated the signing process as more challenging. Despite this, there was a small improvement in the success rate of signing after stamping was completed.

2-Click Edit/Delete

No users complained about the number of clicks to edit or delete settings. This could change after longer use but making changes after initial setup wasn't reported as common. Hiding edit on zones could reduce confusion about the different actions.

Research



Digitally Sign + Stamp
Round 1

Seal + Sign Document
Round 2 A

Apply Certificate + Appearance
Round 2 B

“I don't understand what I'm taking responsibility for. It's a huge thing. I will be legally responsible for whatever this is doing. **It needs to be clear because I'll be responsible of it for 10 years.**"

– Geotechnical Engineer

This was a quote we shared in a later discussion about another feature in the works. After hearing this, the Devs response was “Well I am a user but not that kinda user”.

This felt like the start of the teams separation of viewing themselves as users. An understanding that our users have more at stake in their work using our tool.

Moving Forward

Beta Planning

Pre-Launch

Hold sessions with a few users to view their experience with the new version:

- Building an appearance
- Creating a zone
- Stamping & signing
- See a working document

Beta Launch

Release the working file to a larger audience and ask that they complete a survey on the following timeline 1 week, 30 and 60 days.

- Ease of use/learnability
- Get data about usage/needs (Self-reported)

Post Beta Interviews

Review survey feedback and see if there is any notable experiences we'd like to hear more about, then book interviews with them.

Success Metrics

Scoring From Beta

Does satisfaction and ease of use scores for the new version improve through out the time period?

Satisfaction Score

After the version 4 release, how does the satisfaction metric in the marketing survey change? Does the number of very satisfied users grow?

Support Stats

Customer Support is switching to a new tracking system. What are the common customer issues and what changes after 4?

Closing Thoughts

I am pleased with the work I did after joining the project so late in addition to never working on a desktop app before.

After working on the project for nearly a year and with new insights, I believe this next design was on its way to being the closest to what users needed to complete their work.

I am sad that I didn’t get to share it with the team and hear their thoughts on it to further refine the experience.

Marisa Bivi

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